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▶ JUDICIARY

JUDGING THEMSELVES

The Supreme Court opens up on judges' assets and appointments in an unprecedented act of transparency and self-scrutiny

BY KAUSHIK DEKA

The Supreme Court of India has embarked on an unprecedented transparency drive. Late on the night of May 5, it quietly uploaded an unusual set of documents to its official website, making public the personal asset declarations of 23 of its 33 sitting judges. It also noted that the remaining disclosures would be uploaded "as and when" submitted. Alongside this, the court also released detailed records of its typically opaque appointment process. This disclosure followed a unanimous resolution at a Full Court meeting held on April 1, where all SC justices agreed that judges' asset declarations must be placed in the public domain.

The move comes amid intensifying scrutiny of the judiciary, including allegations of corruption, nepotism, caste bias and a lack of accountability in how judges are appointed. Two recent flashpoints proved to be catalysts: a 'cash-for-justice' scandal involving Delhi High Court Judge Yashwant Varma, and unusually sharp public criticism from Vice President Jagdeep Dhankhar over judicial opacity

Illustration by RAJ VERMA